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Achan

The soldier whose hidden theft at Jericho brought defeat on all Israel.

Achan was a man of Judah who fought at Jericho. God had said everything in the city was devoted to him, and nothing was to be kept. Achan saw a fine robe, silver and a bar of gold, wanted them, and buried them under his tent. No one knew. But when Israel attacked the small town of Ai, the army ran and thirty-six men died. By lot the guilt was traced to one man. Achan confessed, and he died in the valley of Achor, "trouble." His story shows how one person's secret sin can harm a whole community.

At a glance

Name	Akhan, meaning uncertain; "Achar" in 1 Chronicles 2:7
Family	Son of Carmi, of the tribe of Judah (Joshua 7:1, 18)
When	Just after Jericho fell, c. 1406 BC (late view c. 1220 BC)
Key places	Jericho, Ai, the valley of Achor
Key people	Joshua; the men of Ai; his sons and daughters
What he took	A garment, 200 shekels of silver, a wedge of gold (Joshua 7:21)
Main passages	Joshua 7; 22:20; 1 Chronicles 2:7
New Testament	Not named

"And Achan answered Joshua, and said, Indeed I have sinned against the LORD God of Israel, and thus and thus have I done:"

Joshua 7:20, KJV

The life of Achan

Dates follow the early date of the Exodus. On the late date, these events fall c. 1220 BC. Scripture gives no age for Achan. All of his story comes from a few days.

- c. 1406 BC

At Jericho

● Takes the devoted things

Israel is told that Jericho and all in it are devoted to the LORD. Achan takes some of the spoil for himself, and God's anger burns against Israel. *Joshua 6:17-19; 7:1*
- c. 1406 BC

At Ai

● Israel is routed

Spies advise sending only two or three thousand men. About three thousand go up, flee before the men of Ai, and lose thirty-six men. *Joshua 7:2-5*
- c. 1406 BC

The next morning

● Taken by lot

Joshua brings Israel near by tribes. Judah is taken, then the Zarhites, then Zabdi's household, and finally Achan. *Joshua 7:10-18*
- c. 1406 BC

Before Joshua

● Confesses

Achan admits what he saw, coveted, took and hid. Messengers run to his tent and find the goods buried there. *Joshua 7:19-23*
- c. 1406 BC

In the valley of Achor

● Dies

Achan is stoned, and a great heap of stones is raised over him. Then the LORD turns from his anger. *Joshua 7:24-26*

Group notes

Key activities

Joshua 7:24–25 says Achan's sons and daughters were taken to the valley with him, and "all Israel stoned him." Readers differ on whether the family was put to death with him, and if so whether they shared in hiding the goods. Deuteronomy 24:16 forbids punishing children for a parent's sin.

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- 1 Fought at Jericho.** He was among the men who marched and saw the walls fall. *Joshua 6:1–21*
 - 2 Coveted and took.** In his own words: "I saw ... then I coveted them, and took them." *Joshua 7:21*
 - 3 Hid the goods.** He buried them in the ground inside his tent, with the silver underneath. *Joshua 7:21–22*
 - 4 Stayed silent.** He said nothing while Israel was routed at Ai and Joshua lay on his face before the ark. *Joshua 7:5–9*
 - 5 Was found out.** God pointed him out step by step through the lot. *Joshua 7:14–18*
 - 6 Confessed.** Joshua called him "My son" and urged him to give glory to God and tell the truth. He did. *Joshua 7:19–21*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Achan.

Old Testament

Joshua 7:1–26	The main account
Joshua 22:20	"That man perished not alone in his iniquity"
1 Chronicles 2:7	"Achar, the troubler of Israel"
Hosea 2:15; Isaiah 65:10	Achor becomes a "door of hope"
Echo: Genesis 3:6	Eve also saw, desired and took
Echo: 1 Samuel 15:9–23	Saul also kept what was devoted

New Testament

Echo: Acts 5:1–11	Ananias and Sapphira keep back part and lie
Echo: James 1:14–15	Sin traced from desire to action
Echo: 1 Corinthians 5:6	"A little leaven leaveneth the whole lump"

For discussion

- Observe:* List the four verbs in Achan's confession (Joshua 7:21). What does each step show?
- Understand:* Why did God treat Achan's private sin as the sin of all Israel (Joshua 7:1, 11)?
- Apply:* Achan buried what he took under his own tent. What might people "bury" today and hope no one finds?
- Apply:* Hosea turns the valley of trouble into a door of hope. Where do you need to hear that confession can lead to a fresh start?